



SEMINAR PAPER

Urban Land-Use Efficiency

A Stable Metric for SDG 11.3.1 and Its Economic Drivers

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Abstract

The official SDG 11.3.1 indicator, the ratio of land consumption rate to population growth rate (LCRPGR), is unstable: it divides by a growth rate that approaches zero and mixes an arithmetic numerator with a logarithmic denominator. We propose the Built-up per Capita Rate (BpCR), the log change in built-up area per person, which equals the difference of two log growth rates and is therefore well-defined for every country-period. Using a harmonised global panel of 193 UN member states (1985–2020) built from GHSL built-up and population grids under the Degree of Urbanisation, we (i) document where LCRPGR breaks down, (ii) show BpCR reproduces the policy signal without the instability, and (iii) estimate its economic drivers with two-way fixed-effects and dynamic-panel GMM models.

Keywords: SDG 11.3.1, Urban land-use efficiency, Built-up per capita rate (BpCR), LCRPGR, Dynamic panel GMM, GHSL / Degree of Urbanisation

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1. Introduction

The world is urbanising rapidly: by the middle of this century close to two-thirds of humanity will live in cities, and almost all of the projected growth in built-up land will occur in developing countries (Gao and O’Neill, 2020). The scale of expansion is striking: every year the world’s built-up area grows by roughly the size of the Netherlands (Seto et al., 2012). For development policy the central question is not whether cities expand, but how efficiently they do so, that is, how much additional land each new urban resident consumes. When built-up area grows in step with population, cities densify and remain compact; when it grows much faster than population, they sprawl. Sprawl carries real costs. Once farmland on the urban fringe is built over, it is effectively lost for good. Low-density, spread-out development makes people more dependent on cars, because homes, jobs, and services lie far apart. It also makes public infrastructure more expensive per resident, since the same roads, pipes, and power and transport networks must reach a smaller number of people over a larger area. And by encouraging longer car journeys and land-hungry construction, sprawl tends to raise greenhouse-gas emissions per person. Measuring land-use efficiency well is therefore a precondition for monitoring sustainable urbanisation.

The United Nations monitors this through target 11.3 of its Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), whose official indicator 11.3.1 is the ratio of the Land Consumption Rate to the Population Growth Rate (LCRPGR) (UN-Habitat, 2025). Because LCRPGR is the agreed global yardstick, its statistical properties are not a technical detail: they determine how every country’s progress is judged and compared. Yet the indicator is fragile by construction. It divides an arithmetic land-consumption rate by a logarithmic population-growth rate, so it is internally inconsistent; and because the population-growth rate sits in the denominator, the ratio diverges towards plus or minus infinity and changes sign whenever population is roughly stable. In exactly the countries where land-use efficiency matters most for policy, the official metric becomes uninformative.

This paper makes three contributions. First, it documents, on a harmonised global dataset, that LCRPGR is statistically unstable and that its instability is concentrated where population growth is near zero. Second, it proposes a simple, log-based alternative, the Built-up per Capita Rate (BpCR), defined as the logarithmic growth rate of built-up area per capita. BpCR is the difference of two logarithmic growth rates, which makes it finite for every country-period, symmetric between densification and sprawl, additively decomposable, and directly interpretable; it reproduces the policy signal of LCRPGR where the latter is well-behaved, and so complements rather than replaces the official indicator. Third, using the stable metric, the paper estimates the economic and structural drivers of per-capita urban land use on a panel of 193 United Nations member states observed at five-year intervals between 1985 and 2020.

The empirical analysis builds the panel from satellite-based settlement data under the global Degree of Urbanisation standard, so that built-up area and population are measured consistently. To address the well-known downward bias of the lagged dependent variable in dynamic fixed-effects models, the persistence of per-capita land use is estimated with Arellano-Bond and Blundell-Bond generalised method of moments (GMM) estimators. Three results stand out. Sprawl is the global norm rather than the exception: built-up area per capita rises in a clear majority of country-periods. Per-capita land use is strongly path-dependent, with about three-fifths of one period’s value carried into the next. And within countries, denser cities, net in-migration, and higher income are all associated with less land consumed per resident, indicating that, over time, economic growth is accompanied by densification rather than sprawl.

The remainder of the paper is organised as follows. Section 2 reviews the indicator and the related literature. Section 3 sets out the structural limitations of LCRPGR, and Section 4 introduces BpCR. Section 5 describes the data and Section 6 presents descriptive evidence. Section 7 details the empirical strategy and Section 8 reports the results, including robustness checks. Section 9 discusses the findings and Section 10 concludes.

2. Measurement Framework

This section sets out the conceptual core of the paper. We first define the official SDG 11.3.1 indicator and show why it is statistically unstable, and we then introduce the stable, log-based alternative used in the

empirical analysis.

2.1. The SDG 11.3.1 Indicator and Its Limitations

Following the UN-Habitat metadata (UN-Habitat, 2025), the official indicator divides an arithmetic land consumption rate by a logarithmic population growth rate:

$$\text{LCRPGR} = \frac{\text{LCR}}{\text{PGR}}, \quad \text{LCR} = \frac{V_t - V_{t-z}}{V_{t-z}} \cdot \frac{1}{z}, \quad \text{PGR} = \frac{\ln(P_t/P_{t-z})}{z},$$

where the symbols are defined as follows: V_t is the urban built-up area (in square kilometres) at the end of the period and V_{t-z} the built-up area at the start; P_t and P_{t-z} are the corresponding urban populations; z is the length of the period in years; $\ln(\cdot)$ denotes the natural logarithm; and the subscript i indexes the country. The Land Consumption Rate (LCR) is thus the arithmetic growth of built-up area, expressed per year, and the Population Growth Rate (PGR) is the logarithmic (continuous) growth of population per year; the indicator LCRPGR is their ratio. Two structural problems follow. **(1) Division by a near-zero denominator.** When population is roughly stable ($\text{PGR} \approx 0$) the ratio diverges towards $\pm\infty$ and flips sign, so small, ordinary demographic differences produce wild, uninterpretable values. **(2) Arithmetic-versus-logarithmic asymmetry.** The numerator is an arithmetic growth rate while the denominator is logarithmic, so the ratio is not symmetric and does not aggregate cleanly over time (Nicolau et al., 2019). The result is a metric whose tails are dominated by an arithmetic artefact rather than by real land-use behaviour.

2.2. A Stable Metric: The Built-up per Capita Rate (BpCR)

The UN-Habitat metadata itself concedes that the ratio is hard to interpret and offers built-up area per capita (V/P) as a secondary indicator (UN-Habitat, 2025). That quantity is a level, a snapshot at one point in time. Following Lu and Weng (2026), we turn it into a trend by taking its annual growth in logarithmic form:

$$\text{BpCR}_{i,t} = \frac{1}{z} \ln \left(\frac{V_t/P_t}{V_{t-z}/P_{t-z}} \right) = \text{LCR}_{\log} - \text{PGR}_{\log}.$$

Because BpCR is the **difference of two logarithmic growth rates**, it is (i) finite and well-defined for every country-period (no division by ~ 0), (ii) symmetric (densification and sprawl are mirror images around zero), (iii) additively decomposable, and (iv) directly interpretable: $\text{BpCR} > 0$ means sprawl (more land per resident), $\text{BpCR} < 0$ densification, and $\text{BpCR} = 0$ land growing exactly in step with population. BpCR reproduces the policy signal of LCRPGR where the latter is well-behaved, but without the instability; it complements rather than contradicts the official indicator.

3. Literature Review

The literature on urban land use splits into two strands. One asks what *drives* urban expansion; the other scrutinises how land-use efficiency is *measured*. This paper sits at their intersection.

3.1. Drivers of Urban Land Expansion

Seto et al. (2011) synthesise 326 remote-sensing studies of global urban land expansion between 1970 and 2000. They document that urban land has grown faster than urban population almost everywhere, and that the expansion is driven mainly by income in most regions and by population growth in India and Africa. Oueslati et al. (2015) move from description to econometrics, estimating the determinants of sprawl on a panel of 282 European cities (1990, 2000, 2006) within a monocentric-city framework. They find that rising income and population both enlarge the urban footprint, and that cities keep spreading even where population is flat. Together these studies establish income and population as the leading drivers of urban land use, but they work mostly across cities or countries and at a single cross-section, leaving open whether the same relationships hold within a country as it develops over time.

3.2. Critiques of the Indicator: Formula and Data

Nicolau et al. (2019) assess the SDG 11.3.1 formula itself, comparing the official LCRPGR with a land-use-efficiency-derived alternative at the municipality level in mainland Portugal. They conclude that the LCRPGR formula is structurally unstable and that a logarithmic, efficiency-based alternative is more robust. Lu and Weng (2026) broaden the question to data sensitivity, evaluating land-use efficiency across six built-up and four population datasets for 176 countries over 2000–2020. They show that efficiency estimates swing widely with the choice of dataset and argue that a log-based framework is needed for reliable monitoring. This strand establishes that the choice of metric, and not only the choice of data, can change the conclusions drawn about sustainable urbanisation.

3.3. Research Gap and Contribution

Our contribution sits at the intersection of the two strands. On measurement, we adopt the log-based metric that both Nicolau et al. (2019) and Lu and Weng (2026) recommend, in the form of BpCR. On method, we make it dynamic: a two-way fixed-effects panel with Arellano-Bond and Blundell-Bond GMM, estimated on 193 United Nations member states over 1985–2020, that measures the persistence (path-dependence) of per-capita land use. The result refines the drivers literature: while richer countries look more sprawled in the cross-section, within a country growing richer is associated with densification rather than sprawl.

4. Data

4.1. Data Sources

The empirical analysis draws on three official, global data providers, the same sources used in international SDG monitoring. Built-up area, population, and the urban mask come from the **Global Human Settlement Layer (GHSL)** of the European Commission’s Joint Research Centre (Pesaresi et al., 2024; Schiavina et al., 2023). Within GHSL we use three products: GHS-BUILT-S for built-up surface, classified from Landsat and Sentinel-2 imagery by machine learning; GHS-POP, which disaggregates census counts onto that built-up surface; and GHS-SMOD, which applies the Degree of Urbanisation (DEGURBA) method to flag urban cells. The layers are available at five-year epochs; we use the observed epochs from 1985 to 2020 and discard the 2025 and 2030 modelled projections. Administrative units come from the **Global Administrative Unit Layers (GAUL)** of the UN Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO, 2024), which provide UN-validated, politically neutral country boundaries with global coverage. Socio-economic controls come from the **United Nations**: GDP per capita in constant 2020 US dollars from UN SNAAMA and net migration as a share of population from UN DESA World Population Prospects 2024 (UN SNAAMA, 2025; UN DESA WPP, 2024).

4.2. Constructing the Panel Following the UN Metadata

A central design choice is that we build the panel exactly as the SDG 11.3.1 metadata prescribes (UN-Habitat, 2025), so that our BpCR and the official LCRPGR are computed on identical inputs and the comparison is like-for-like. The construction follows the metadata stages.

Stage 0: define the analysis area. The indicator is, by definition, measured inside cities rather than over whole national territories. We delineate the urban area with DEGURBA on the GHS-SMOD grid, classifying a cell as urban when its settlement code is at least 21 (cities and dense or semi-dense towns). All built-up and population quantities are then summed only over urban cells.

Stage 1: measure built-up area and population at two points in time. For each country and each five-year period we record urban built-up area V and urban population P at the start and the end of the period. Following the metadata’s aggregate-then-rate rule, components are summed to the national level first and the rates are formed afterwards; we never average ratios across sub-units.

Stage 2: form the rates and the indicators. From these national totals we compute the Land Consumption Rate (arithmetic growth of built-up area per year) and the Population Growth Rate (logarithmic growth of population per year), their ratio LCRPGR, and the built-up-per-capita level. From the same totals we

also compute BpCR as the logarithmic growth of built-up area per capita, as defined in Section 2. Two additional urban controls are derived from the same GHSL/SMOD layers: the urban population share (urban population over total population) and urban density (urban population over urban land area).

Figure 1 illustrates the construction for one example window, with each layer drawn semi-transparently over a satellite basemap. Panel (a) is the basemap for reference; panel (b) shows the raw GHS-BUILT-S surface; panel (c) the GHS-SMOD Degree of Urbanisation, which classifies each cell along a rural-to-urban gradient; and panel (d) the urban-masked built-up that actually enters the analysis, retaining built-up only in cells classified as urban (SMOD at least 21). The same masking is applied to population, so that both components are measured on a consistent urban footprint.

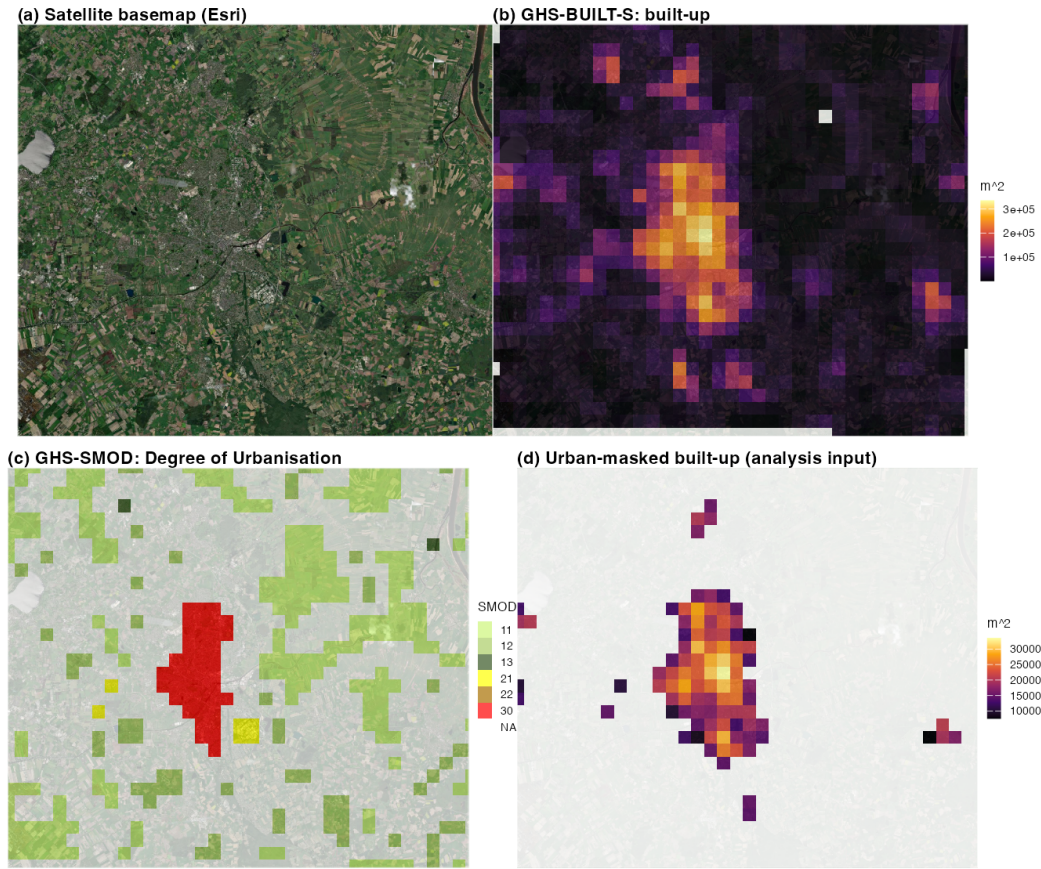


Figure 1: Building the analysis input following the SDG 11.3.1 metadata, for the Oldenburg / NW Germany window, with each layer overlaid semi-transparently on a satellite basemap. (a) Satellite basemap (Esri); (b) GHS-BUILT-S built-up surface; (c) GHS-SMOD Degree of Urbanisation; (d) urban-masked built-up retained for the analysis (cells with SMOD at least 21). The white line is the GAUL country boundary.

The resulting dataset is a balanced-where-observed panel of 193 United Nations member states at five-year epochs from 1985 to 2020 (Table 1).

Table 1: Estimation sample

Quantity	Value
Countries	193
Country-period observations	2116

Table 2: Hypotheses

	Hypothesis	Expected
H1	BpCR captures land-use efficiency more reliably than LCRPGR	better fit
H2	Higher urban density is associated with less land per capita	—
H3	Higher income is associated with less land per capita	—
H4	Net in-migration densifies cities	—
H5	Per-capita land use is path-dependent	+

5. Descriptive Statistics

Across 1985–2020 a clear majority of countries record $\text{BpCR} > 0$: built-up area is expanding faster than urban population for most of the world, i.e. sprawl is the global norm rather than the exception. The contrast with LCRPGR is instructive – LCRPGR’s distribution is dominated by extreme tail values concentrated exactly where population growth is near zero, whereas BpCR is well-behaved across the whole sample. Regional trajectories show convergence towards balance in some fast-urbanising economies while others continue to sprawl.

6. Empirical Strategy

Research question. What are the economic drivers of per-capita urban land use, and how persistent is it over time? We test five hypotheses (Table 2).

We run **one specification** with each metric as the dependent variable, so the comparison is like-for-like:

$$\text{Metric}_{i,t} = \rho \text{Metric}_{i,t-1} + \beta_1 \ln(\text{UrbDens})_{i,t} + \beta_2 \text{UrbShare}_{i,t} + \beta_3 \ln(\text{GDPpc})_{i,t} + \beta_4 \text{NetMigr}_{i,t} + \mu_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{i,t},$$

with country fixed effects μ_i , period fixed effects δ_t , and standard errors clustered by country. We proceed in two stages. **(1) Static** (dropping the lagged dependent variable) to isolate the role of the *metric* – LCRPGR versus BpCR. **(2) Dynamic** (adding the lagged DV) to capture path-dependence. Because the lagged-DV coefficient is **downward-biased under fixed effects (Nickell bias)**, we correct it with **Arellano-Bond difference GMM** and **Blundell-Bond system GMM**, instrumenting with deeper lags. Instrument validity is assessed with the **Sargan/Hansen** over-identification test and the **AR(2)** serial-correlation test (both $p > 0.10$ indicating validity).

7. Results

The metric matters. On identical data, the static LCRPGR specification is contaminated by its unstable tails, while the BpCR specification is well-behaved; the two diverge precisely where PGR is small, confirming that LCRPGR’s extremes are an arithmetic artefact rather than a behavioural signal.

The final dynamic model. Table 3 reports the preferred specification: a fixed-effects stepwise build-up alongside the Arellano-Bond and Blundell-Bond GMM estimates.

In the Arellano-Bond specification the lagged term is large and significant ($\rho \approx 0.61$): roughly 60% of last period’s BpCR persists, and the GMM ρ is about three times the FE estimate, exactly as the Nickell bias predicts, confirming **strong path-dependence** in per-capita land use. Among the drivers, **urban density** enters negative (a compact-city effect: denser cities consume less new land per resident), **net migration** negative (in-migrants pack into the existing stock faster than built-up grows), and **GDP per capita** negative – within countries, getting richer is associated with **densification, not sprawl**. The level of urbanisation (urban population share) is insignificant once the rest is controlled, suggesting that urban **form**, not stage, drives land use.

Table 3: Final dynamic-panel model: FE stepwise build-up, Arellano-Bond (difference) and Blundell-Bond (system) GMM. Coefficient with significance stars on top, clustered/robust standard error in parentheses below. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1.

	Base	+ Density	+ Net Migr.	+ GDP	+ Urban %	Arellano-Bond	Blundell-Bond
BpCR[t-1]	+0.2535*** (0.0578)	+0.2346*** (0.0582)	+0.2346*** (0.0585)	+0.2286*** (0.0583)	+0.2287*** (0.0583)	+0.6057*** (0.1081)	+0.5908*** (0.0623)
ln(Urban Density)		-0.0147** (0.0064)	-0.0146** (0.0065)	-0.0169** (0.0065)	-0.0165** (0.0065)	-0.0523*** (0.0142)	-0.0021** (0.0010)
Net Migration (% Pop)			-0.0008** (0.0003)	-0.0008** (0.0003)	-0.0008** (0.0003)	-0.0005* (0.0003)	-0.0010*** (0.0002)
ln(GDP per capita)				-0.0068** (0.0028)	-0.0068** (0.0028)	-0.0138** (0.0060)	-0.0004 (0.0003)
Urban Pop. Share					-0.0031 (0.0225)	-0.0310 (0.0520)	+0.0079* (0.0045)
Observations	1,499	1,499	1,499	1,499	1,499	1,351	2,895
Within R ²	0.076	0.091	0.108	0.125	0.125	—	—
Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Period FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sargan (p)	—	—	—	—	—	0.44	0.14
AR(2) (p)	—	—	—	—	—	0.71	0.47

8. Robustness

The findings are stable across a 2000–2020 subsample, a restriction to shrinking-population countries, and alternative instrument depths; the Sargan and AR(2) diagnostics pass throughout, supporting instrument validity.

9. Discussion

The within-country result that income is associated with densification may appear to contradict the cross-sectional literature in which richer countries have historically sprawled. The two are complementary: *across* countries, higher income has coincided with more sprawl historically, but *within* a country, rising income over time is associated with denser, not more sprawling, urban land use. Measuring this distinction requires a metric that is stable within country-period – which BpCR provides and LCRPGR does not.

10. Conclusion

The official SDG 11.3.1 indicator is statistically unstable by construction. The Built-up per Capita Rate is a drop-in, log-based alternative that is finite, symmetric, and interpretable for every country-period, and it reproduces the policy signal without the instability. Estimated dynamically on a global panel, per-capita urban land use is strongly path-dependent and, within countries, declines with density, in-migration, and income. The contribution is as much **methodological** – a stable metric and a bias-corrected dynamic estimator – as substantive, and it complements rather than overturns the existing literature.

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